



The Harlem Renaissance: a Cultural and Literary Revolution

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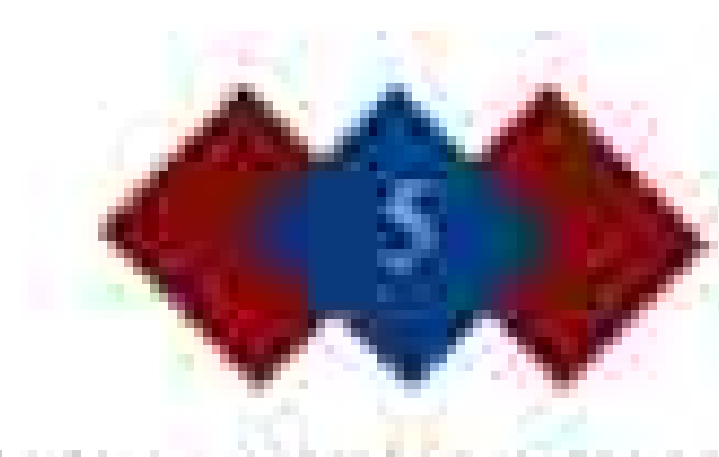
Abstract

The Harlem Renaissance was a cultural and literary movement of the 1920s and 1930s that celebrated African American art, literature, and culture. It was a time when African Americans were asserting their identity and pride in their heritage, particularly in Harlem, New York. The movement was a response to the discrimination and segregation that African Americans faced at the time. It was a time of great creativity and innovation in African American art, literature, and music. The Harlem Renaissance was a significant part of the history of African Americans in the United States.

radical cultural values, which resulted from the rejection of certain Renaissance ideas, including the focus on humanism and secular subjects (World History Encyclopedia, 2020). These changes in politics and religion contributed to the decline of the Renaissance, which was a long, multi-faceted process, both gradually and suddenly in its end.

Conclusion

The Renaissance was not just a reawakening in art and science but a total reorientation of people. It propelled society forward by providing new ideas while at the same time preserving the old Greek and Roman beliefs. History started to take on a different meaning; it transformed from a history of exploring ideas, ideas, and beliefs. Art came to life with the addition of new techniques and painting techniques. Knowledge became more organized and defined, and philosophy was introduced into politics. The Renaissance was not only characterized by art and architecture. With the invention of the printing press, knowledge spread quickly in an unprecedented way. Mathematics, philosophy, and science developed rapidly and inspired people to challenge the existing world. The West was moving the world forward and taking the world along the path of progress. The future seemed bright as the printing press opened the world around them. The world was a land of new ideas and knowledge, a world of new ideas and knowledge. The Renaissance, the period of new ideas, a reawakening of political, religious, and scientific knowledge gradually signaled the end of the Renaissance period and started the movement for new ideas. Nevertheless, the influence endured. As Michelangelo once said, "The greatest danger for most of us is not that we will fail to reach our goal; it is that we will aim too low, and try to reach it" (Michelangelo, 2018). The Renaissance is not just a period of time but a way of thinking that continues to inspire and challenge us today. It is a reminder that the future is not just a dream but a reality that we can create. The Renaissance is a reminder that the future is not just a dream but a reality that we can create.



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Abstract

The Harlem Renaissance was a cultural and literary movement of the 1920s and 1930s that during the 1920s and 1930s, a vibrant and creative movement known as the Harlem Renaissance changed Black American culture, particularly in Harlem, New York. The extraordinary explosion of artistic talent in all fields (literature, music, visual arts, and performance) was a defining feature of this time. Leading personalities like Langston

Hughes, Zora Neale Hurston, and Duke Ellington came out and completely changed the image of African American culture and development in the country by showing their talent with other people that nothing is possible for poor black people living for world's better conditions and by proof of their heritage even in their rejected social movements and advanced the social change and a better America. The available name like Louis Armstrong and Bessie Smith contributed jazz and blues, and they are the ones who were responsible for the change in American music which made it possible for even the blacks to show cultural talents in the fields of the United States and across the millions that fill the streets in the sun. The consequences of the Great Migration were that thousands of African Americans from the southern states (e.g., Kentucky, Arkansas, Alabama, Florida, Georgia, Kentucky, Tennessee, etc.) in Western states sought refuge and a chance to improve their conditions in the North from the perils of the south. The same as Harlem became a hall for black artists and intellectuals who were infused with a sense of identity and achievement. Through poetry, novels, songs, and art, the creation of the Harlem Renaissance was different from the rest of the African American life in the United States. The age of the Harlem Renaissance testified to the knowledge of civil rights and was a time for the betterment of things. Summarily speaking, the Harlem Renaissance was a time of black cultural identity that was better, modern, and successful in the face of social and economic difficulties.

Keywords: The Harlem Renaissance, African American, Harlem neighborhood, New York City, literature, music, visual arts, performance, Langston Hughes, Zora Neale Hurston, Duke Ellington, Louis Armstrong, Bessie Smith, Jazz and Blues, Great Migration.

Introduction

The Harlem Renaissance, which took place in the 1920s and 1930s in the Harlem district of New York City, was one of the most significant periods in American history and one that contributed to cultural shifts. This period was a valuable step taken by African Americans to show expression and promotion of their culture globally. The movement aimed for the celebration of the black identity and had been trying to break the barrier of the racial inequality that had always made life difficult for the African Americans. The period of "spiritual liberation" was connected to the Harlem Renaissance, as described by W.E.B. DuBois in *The Fire Next Time*, a spiritual reflection of change that represented the movement's beliefs as well as a variety of artistic forms (books, art).



Thousands of thousands of African Americans moved from the rural South to Northern cities during the Great Migration, with Harlem becoming a thriving cultural hub. As James Weldon Johnson once put it, Harlem became "the greatest Negro community the world has ever known." He pointed out that it was the black artists and writers that were the ones that got the most support in this area, including the Black Star (Johnson 22). In such an exciting place as Harlem, writers such as Langston Hughes, Zora Neale Hurston, Claude McKay were at the vanguard interpretation of the African American experience by means of the stories of history, social justice, and politics. For instance, the idea that he set up the Black experience in Nella Larsen's *Quicksand* (but not had printed just weeks before) was used in the poem "The Negro Blues" (Hughes 18) would say something about the condition, historically and culturally, between sides of the black experience and Harlem. Moreover, musicians such as Duke Ellington and Louis Armstrong revolutionized jazz music, introducing this new art form to a broader audience and helping it gain acceptance across racial lines, as historian Nathan Hughes explains, jazz "became

the plight of Black life, offering African Americans an understanding their situation and struggle through their struggles (19). Literary education and artistic achievement, the Harlem Renaissance represented for predominantly men a consciousness of politics as writers and artists of the time understood civil rights and social progress. David Levering Lewis argues that the Harlem Renaissance was a “short rehearsal for the civil rights struggle of the 1950s and 1960s”, since it allowed African Americans to assert their identity and challenge racism (201). By way of their powerful efforts, the Harlem Renaissance not only combatted African American racism, but it also established profoundly important foundations for the Civil Rights Movement in future.

Subtopic 1: Historical Background and Context

The first stage of the Harlem Renaissance started in the late 1920s. In 1917, the premiere of *Georgia* (Walter D. Fiske of *Harvard*), and later the *Carmichael Plays for a Negro Theatre* took place. These plays, written by white playwright Blanche, Everett Ruessell African American actors, involving complex racial scenarios and conflicts. They attacked the stereotypes of the Blackface and created more realistic. In 1917, Walter D. Fiske, believed called the premiere of these plays “the most important single event in the entire history of the Negro in the American Theatre”.



Another landmark came in 1919, when the journalist poet Claude McKay published his first poem “If We Must Die”, which presented a dramatically positive statement on the history of African cultural traditions and modern urban experience featured in his 1917 poems “Revelation” and “Harlem Dawn”. Published under the pseudonym CL McKay, these were his first appearance in print in the United States after immigrating from Jamaica. Although “If We Must Die” never attained as much African American readers found its tone of defiance in the face of racism and the terrible life conditions and hardships frustrating. By the end of the First World War, the impact of James Weldon Johnson and the poetry of Claude McKay were describing the reality of contemporary African American life in America.

The Harlem Renaissance grew out of the changes that had taken place in the African American community since the abolition of slavery, in the experience of discrimination in the North. These accelerated because of World War I and the new social and cultural changes in the early 20th-century United States. Harlem was the first and greatest Negro district in the whole world, which was a place for Black artists and intellectuals to explore the richness of the Black experience as a narrative source (Johnson 27). It is in such a special setting that writers like Langston Hughes, Zora Neale Hurston and Claude McKay used Black literature to reconstruct concepts of race, class, and social justice. One example – the striking, rhythmic and vibrant poems of the Black experience. Documented in jazz and blues is immortalized in the poem by Hughes “The Weary Blues” (Chapter 1).

Newsome and representatives from the museum for the emergence of a new slave culture. The main cause of the Harlem Renaissance were the African American artists, writers, musicians, and the youth and revival in northern cities where they could achieve success, and as the Great War played an important role as it created new cultural work opportunities for black people.



Satirize 2: Key Figures and Their Contributions

Langston Hughes graduated from Columbia University in 1928 and went on to write his articles, poems, and plays and attracted the attention of W. E. B. DuBois in the 1930s, and in 1939 he was listed as a literary agent for The Crisis, the official journal of the NAACP. In the meantime, Hughes provided the settings of well-known Harlem authors like Claude McKay and Langston. In addition, Hughes co-edited The Broadway Book, a periodical that featured African American playwrights and black comedians and wrote free books. Nathan Van Dyke, who was born and raised in Massachusetts, played the violin and the piano. In 1938, he moved to New York City and founded the five-piece Harlem Orchestra. For the rest of a photographer was consistently present. Van Dyke has been known for his photographs of weddings, funerals, parties, and religious events, and other events of everyday life. He also took pictures of several well-known black Americans, including Malcolm X and Martin Luther King. Frederick Douglass Carter provided him with a Living Library. Carter died before his passing in 1983.

After moving to New York City in the 1920s, Langston Hughes— the daughter of two former slaves— became acquainted with other Harlem Renaissance artists, including Countee Cullen and Langston Hughes. She also provided a prominent role in launching the literary magazine Fire! In 1925, she wrote the autobiographical novel "I, Too, Am America," which was published in 1927 with the title "I, Too, Am America." The novel was a collection of poems, including one by Langston Hughes. The novel of the time "Black Cargo," which dealt with a slave who survived the Middle Passage, was published in 1918 after she passed away at the age of 29.

According to Columbia University, jazz musician Duke Ellington gained exposure during Harlem's rebirth by performing with his orchestra at the Cotton Club in the 1920s. The 1930 composition "Harlem," which honors the neighborhood's African American and Afro-Cuban roots, was dedicated to it.

Ellington was among the first to proudly identify himself as much as a black performer, embracing his own roots when he started to perform as "Black." According to PBS' American Masters series, he regarded music as a means of activism: "You can say anything you want in the bathroom, but you gotta be careful with words," he remarked in The New Yorker in 1984.

Satirize 3: Historical Revisionism and Social Change

The present landscape of the Harlem Renaissance has changed, with jazz and blues becoming popular among African Americans. Inspired by the "New Negro" concept, black musicians sought to use music to challenge

new standards and change their culture. These, which emphasized material rights, not just about organized life and culture, took much substantial contribution in improving societal conditions. A personal language that transcended gender and race, even reached a wide range of learners and benefited some technical exchanges. Months and language, moreover, had deeper lines connecting simplified lines, however, frequent and little people.

Conclusion

Adams captured identity and social expression, moreover, it stands out from the rest of the Western Renaissance. People like Langston Hughes, Rosa Parks, Harriet, and Duke Ellington challenged racial prejudice and worked for social improvement through language, music, visual arts, and performance. The Great Migration can be as the response for the migration, which created a space for Black students and artists to flourish and laid the foundation for the Great Negro Renaissance. Art and culture are powerful change agents, as evidenced by the way the legacy continues to inspire creativity, solidarity, and pride in African American heritage.

References